

Edinburgh Castle - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Castle Rock: Geology as Destiny

Edinburgh Castle stands on a 350-million-year-old volcanic plug whose crag-and-tail formation dictated the entire shape of the city — and its military history. With sheer basalt on three sides, the rock has carried fortifications for perhaps three thousand years, and the castle proper claims the title of most besieged place in Britain, with some twenty-six sieges. Two are worth carrying with you. In March 1314, months before Bannockburn, Thomas Randolph, Earl of Moray, retook the English-held castle by escalade up the “unclimbable” north face, guided by William Francis, a member of the garrison in earlier years who had pioneered the route on nocturnal visits to a woman in the town — thirty men, ladders, total surprise. Robert the Bruce then ordered the castle’s defenses slighted so the English could never hold it again, sparing only St Margaret’s Chapel — which is why that tiny Romanesque building, circa 1130, survives as the oldest structure in Edinburgh. The second is the Lang Siege of 1571 to 73, when the castle held out for Mary, Queen of Scots long after her cause was lost, ending only when English heavy guns reduced David’s Tower to rubble; the Half Moon Battery you see dominating the approach was built directly on and around the tower’s remains — the castle’s silhouette is literally a scar of that siege. Almost nothing you’ll walk through predates it except the chapel and the Great Hall; this is less a preserved castle than an accumulation of reconstructions, each following a catastrophe.

Tell Me More: The Castle as Working Fortress

Details that reward a second look as you walk the wards. The castle remains a working military site — the Army’s presence is real, not costumed — which is why it houses the National War Museum and regimental museums of the Royal Scots and Scots Greys; the Scots Greys’ gallery includes relics of their legendary charge at Waterloo. The Half Moon Battery’s guns point, tellingly, down the Royal Mile — the fortress’s real vulnerability was always the town side, and after the 1745 Jacobite rising (when Bonnie Prince Charlie held the city but never took the castle, its guns bombarding his supporters’ houses), the government re-engineered approaches to the castle with defense in mind. Below the Great Hall lie the vaults that held prisoners of war from the American Revolutionary and Napoleonic wars — the reconstructed prison displays doors carved with original graffiti including an early depiction of the Stars and Stripes cut by an American privateer’s sailor, and records of a thriving prisoner economy forging banknotes and carving bone trinkets for sale; there were escapes, including a mass breakout in 1811 through a hole in the south wall. The dog cemetery on the ramparts, garrison mascots since the 1840s, is best viewed from above near St Margaret’s Chapel. And a good arriving-fact for the esplanade: it hosts the Royal Edinburgh Military Tattoo each August — grandstands may already be under construction as you visit — and was legally deemed Nova Scotian territory in the 1620s so Scottish colonists’ baronets could be created “on” their lands; Nova Scotia’s flag is the Scottish saltire reversed, a colonial echo that began on this parade ground.

A Volcano Carved by Ice

It’s worth pausing on the rock itself, because the geology here isn’t background scenery, it’s the reason for everything. What you’re standing on is the plug of a volcano that was active around three hundred

and forty million years ago, in the Carboniferous period, when this part of Scotland sat near the equator under warm, shallow seas. The eruptions themselves are long gone, eroded to nothing. What survived is the throat of the volcano, the column of magma that solidified inside the vent into a hard, dark igneous rock called dolerite, closely related to basalt. It's dense, tough, and stubbornly resistant to weathering, which is the whole point.

Then came the ice. During the last great glaciation, an ice sheet perhaps hundreds of metres thick flowed across this landscape, and crucially it moved from west to east. When that grinding mass of ice met the volcanic plug, it couldn't shear it away. Instead it was forced to split and flow around the obstacle, scouring deep hollows on either side, the troughs that today hold Princes Street Gardens on one flank and the Grassmarket on the other. But behind the rock, in its lee, the ice was sheltered, so it left a long protected ramp of softer sedimentary rock and debris trailing away to the east. Geologists call this a crag and tail, and Edinburgh's is the textbook example of the form, cited in earth science courses worldwide.

Understand that shape and you understand the city. The crag is the sheer defensive cliff the castle sits on, unassailable on three sides. The tail is the gentle downhill spine that became the Royal Mile, running from the castle down to Holyrood, with the medieval Old Town's tightly packed closes and tenements crowding along its slopes. The whole distinctive silhouette of historic Edinburgh, that dramatic ridge crowned by a fortress, was dictated by the direction a glacier happened to travel. It also explains the castle's single great weakness, the one you're walking up right now. Every other approach is cliff, so the only viable line of attack was always along the tail, from the town side, which is precisely where the defences are concentrated and where nearly every siege in the castle's history was fought and decided.

The Oldest Room in Edinburgh

Near the summit of the rock stands a small, unassuming stone building that repays a moment of attention out of all proportion to its size. It's Saint Margaret's Chapel, and at roughly nine hundred years old, dating to around eleven thirty, it's the oldest surviving building in Edinburgh, the oldest roofed structure anywhere in the city. It's a plain little Romanesque box, barely sixteen feet by ten inside, with one beautiful chevron-decorated arch separating a tiny nave from a rounded apse. In a fortress that has been demolished and rebuilt more times than almost any castle in Britain, this is the one thing that has stood, more or less continuously, since the twelfth century.

Its survival is not an accident, it's a story about reverence outlasting warfare. When Robert the Bruce took the castle in thirteen fourteen, he ordered its defences systematically slighted, torn down, so the English could never again turn them into a stronghold. Almost every wall and tower came down. The chapel was deliberately spared as consecrated ground, and that same immunity protected it through the destructions that followed, including the artillery bombardment of the Lang Siege two and a half centuries later. The great fortifications of successive kings are dust, and this modest devotional room outlived every one of them.

The Margaret it honours is a remarkable figure in her own right. She was an Anglo-Saxon princess of the old royal house of Wessex, granddaughter of an English king, who fled north after the Norman Conquest of ten sixty-six and married Malcolm the Third, King of Scots, around ten seventy. She was famously pious and charitable, and after her death she was canonised as a saint, one of very few Scottish royal saints. The chapel was built in her memory by her youngest son, King David the First, one of the great medieval Scottish monarchs. There's a nice final irony to the place. Its royal identity was eventually forgotten entirely, and for a long stretch the army used it as a gunpowder store, until the antiquary Sir Daniel Wilson recognised it for what it was in the eighteen forties and had it restored. Today it still hosts weddings and christenings, the oldest building in the city, quietly back in use.

The Honours and the Stone: Objects of State

The Honours of Scotland — crown, scepter, and sword of state, in use together by 1543 — are the oldest surviving crown jewels in Britain, precisely because of two episodes of concealment. When Cromwell invaded in 1650, having already melted the English regalia, the Honours were smuggled from besieged Dunnottar Castle — by tradition lowered down the cliff and carried away by a minister's wife amid bundles of flax — and buried beneath the floor of Kinneff church for nine years. After the Union of 1707 they were locked in a chest in the Crown Room and forgotten for a hundred and eleven years, until Walter Scott — already busy inventing modern Scotland's self-image — obtained a royal warrant in 1818 and opened the sealed room to find them intact. The Stone of Destiny beside them carries even more freight: the inauguration seat of Scottish kings at Scone, seized by Edward the First in 1296 and installed under the Coronation Chair at Westminster as a deliberate statement that Scotland's kingship had been annexed. Every English and British monarch for seven centuries was crowned above it. The 1950 Christmas raid by four Glasgow students — who broke the stone extracting it, hid it, and eventually left it at Arbroath Abbey, site of Scotland's 1320 declaration of independence — embarrassed the state so much that prosecution was declined. The stone returned officially in 1996, was moved to a new home in Perth in 2024, and still travels south for coronations, most recently in 2023. Note the sightline as you leave the Crown Room: these objects sit thirty meters from the room where James the Sixth was born in 1566 — the king who would unite the crowns of the two countries that fought over all of it.

Tell Me More: Scott's Treasure Hunt and Wartime Burial

The 1818 rediscovery of the Honours was theatre directed by Walter Scott, and he knew exactly what he was staging. Post-Union Scotland had spent a century as "North Britain," its national symbols dormant; Scott — then the most famous writer alive and the great impresario of romantic Scottishness — obtained the Prince Regent's warrant to open the sealed Crown Room, gathered commissioners, and broke into the chest before witnesses. His own account describes the moment of lifting the linen and the crowd outside cheering as word spread; one commissioner reaching to place the crown jokingly on a young lady's head drew from Scott a genuinely fierce rebuke — to him these were sacred objects, not props. The find fed directly into his 1822 masterpiece: stage-managing George the Fourth's visit to Edinburgh, the first by a reigning monarch in nearly two centuries, an orgy of invented tartan pageantry (the portly king in a kilt over flesh-colored tights) that rehabilitated Highland dress a generation after it had been banned, and essentially created the tartan-shortbread iconography Scotland has profitably resented ever since. The Second World War buriale: in 1939, fearing invasion, the Honours were hidden within the castle — the crown in a medieval latrine closet beneath David's Tower floor, the case buried elsewhere — with sealed instructions deposited across the Atlantic in Canada, so that even if Britain fell, the location would survive. The regalia thus waited out the Luftwaffe a few meters from their display case, in the fabric of the rock itself — the third time in their history that Scotland's crown survived by burial.

The Birth of a King

Thirty metres from the Crown Room, in the royal apartments of the palace block, is a tiny panelled chamber that changed the course of British history, because a king was born in it. On the nineteenth of June, fifteen sixty-six, Mary, Queen of Scots gave birth here to a son, James. It's a startlingly small and modest room for so consequential an event, and the panelling and painted ceiling you see commemorate the birth. Stand in it and it's hard not to feel the compression of the space against the scale of what followed.

The circumstances were anything but serene. Mary's reign was unravelling into violence and paranoia.

Just three months earlier, while she was six months pregnant, a group of armed conspirators, led by her own husband Lord Darnley, had burst into her supper room at Holyrood and stabbed her Italian secretary David Rizzio to death almost in front of her, some said to frighten her into miscarriage. Darnley was jealous, unstable, and politically dangerous, and he openly cast doubt on whether the child was even his. Tradition holds that Mary, stung by the slander, presented the infant to Darnley and declared before witnesses that this was his son and the son of no other man, a public act of legitimation aimed squarely at the rumours.

What that baby became is the reason the room matters. Within thirteen months Mary was forced to abdicate and the infant was crowned James the Sixth, King of Scots, at Stirling, a toddler monarch with a series of regents ruling in his name. He never saw his mother again, and she was eventually executed in England by her cousin Elizabeth. Yet it was James who inherited everything in the end. When the childless Elizabeth the First died in sixteen oh three, the crown of England passed to him, and the man born in this cramped Edinburgh room became James the First of England as well as James the Sixth of Scots, uniting the two crowns under a single sovereign for the first time. So the long story you've just heard in the Crown Room, of Scotland and England fighting over regalia, thrones, and a lump of sandstone, has one of its great hinges right here, in a chamber you could cross in three paces.

The Stone's New Home

One correction worth carrying into the Crown Room, because guidebooks and memories lag behind the facts. The Stone of Destiny is no longer here. After nearly three decades on display beside the Honours, following its official return from Westminster in nineteen ninety-six, the Stone left Edinburgh Castle for good in March twenty twenty-four. Its last day on the rock was the tenth of March, and it now sits about forty miles north, in the newly opened Perth Museum, which welcomed the public on the thirtieth of March that year. So if you came expecting to see the Stone next to the crown and sceptre, that's why it isn't there.

The move was deliberate and, in its way, a homecoming. The Stone's deepest associations are not with Edinburgh at all but with Scone, just outside Perth, where the medieval kings of Scots were inaugurated seated on or beside it, going back to the ninth century. Edward the First of England carried it off in twelve ninety-six as a trophy of conquest, and it spent seven centuries under the Coronation Chair at Westminster, becoming a fixture of English and then British coronations. Its return to Perthshire in twenty twenty-four marked the first time in more than seven hundred years that the Stone had come back to the landscape it belonged to. Perth built it a purpose-designed gallery inside a restored former city hall, the centrepiece of a twenty-seven-million-pound museum, and visitor numbers surged from the moment it opened.

There's a persistent legend you may hear, and it deserves the honest treatment. When those four students took the Stone from Westminster in nineteen fifty and had it repaired, some have claimed that a copy was made and that the stone handed back to the authorities, the one that travelled here and now sits in Perth, is a replica, with the real Stone hidden away in Scotland. It's a wonderful story, and there's no credible evidence for it, so treat it as folklore rather than fact. What's certain is more interesting anyway. Even now, settled in Perth, the Stone still isn't allowed to rest. Under a standing agreement it must travel south for coronations, and it did exactly that in twenty twenty-three for the crowning of King Charles the Third, journeying to Westminster Abbey and back. After more than a thousand years, this battered block of sandstone is still on the move.

The Gun, the Guns, and the Shrine

The One O’Clock Gun, fired daily except Sundays since 1861, is Greenwich’s time-ball logic adapted to Scottish weather: Leith’s shipping needed a time signal, fog defeats visual signals, so Edinburgh added an audible one — originally triggered by a clock connected to the Nelson Monument’s time ball on Calton Hill by what was claimed as the world’s longest telegraph wire. The one o’clock hour is traditionally explained as economy — one round instead of twelve — which Edinburghers repeat about themselves with pride. Sound-lag maps were genuinely published so citizens could correct for their distance from the castle. Mons Meg, up by St Margaret’s Chapel, is the castle’s other famous barrel: a six-tonne bombard forged at Mons in 1449 and given to James the Second in 1457, capable of throwing a hundred-fifty-kilo gunstone some three kilometers — cutting-edge superweapon of its day, retired after bursting while firing a salute in 1681. But the castle’s emotional center is quieter: the Scottish National War Memorial, opened in 1927 in a converted barrack block, holds the rolls of honour naming every Scottish casualty of the First World War and after — around a hundred fifty thousand from 1914 to 18 alone, a staggering share of a small nation. The shrine stands on the rock’s highest point, the casket of names resting directly on exposed bedrock deliberately left protruding through the marble floor. Even with kids in tow, give it five minutes; it is one of the great war memorials of the world.

Tell Me More: Reading the War Memorial

A little context multiplies the Scottish National War Memorial’s force. Scotland’s Great War losses were proportionally among the worst of any combatant nation — commonly cited at around a quarter of those who served, against lower rates for the UK overall — driven by the Scottish regiments’ heavy use as assault infantry and by recruitment rates that emptied whole communities; some Highland glens and fishing villages lost most of a generation of men in single battalions, on single days. The “pals” pattern made it worse: men enlisted together, served together, died together — McCrae’s Battalion, raised in Edinburgh in 1914 around the Heart of Midlothian football team (the club whose name you saw in the cobbles), lost three-quarters of its strength on the first day of the Somme; the team had been top of the league when its players enlisted en masse. The memorial’s design absorbs this: Robert Lorimer’s 1927 conversion of a barrack block was deliberately not triumphal — no victory figures, but a shrine where the casket of Rolls of Honour rests on raw basalt left protruding through the marble floor, the rock of Scotland itself bearing the names; the stained glass includes scenes of industrial war, women munition workers among them, and the bronze friezes include the animals — horses, mules, carrier pigeons, even mice used to detect gas. Every name is findable: the Rolls are maintained and updated to the present day, and staff will help visitors locate a family name. For American visitors, one resonance: the memorial predates the US national practice — there was no equivalent in Washington until decades later — and its influence on commonwealth memorials worldwide was immediate and lasting.

Mons Meg: Biography of a Superweapon

Up by Saint Margaret’s Chapel sits a squat, monstrous iron barrel that deserves a fuller introduction, because Mons Meg was once among the most fearsome machines on earth. She’s a medieval bombard, a siege cannon built to smash stone walls, and she was cutting-edge military technology of a kind that was rewriting warfare. She was forged in fourteen forty-nine at Mons, in what is now Belgium, by a gunmaker working for Philip the Good, Duke of Burgundy, then one of the richest and most sophisticated rulers in Europe. The Duke gave her to James the Second of Scotland in fourteen fifty-seven as a diplomatic gift, a gesture of alliance, and for a poor northern kingdom to receive a weapon like this was a genuine coup.

Look at how she’s made, because it tells you her age. Meg isn’t cast as a single piece of bronze like later

cannon. She's built the old way, from long wrought-iron staves welded lengthwise and then bound with a series of thick iron hoops shrunk on around them, the same principle as a wooden barrel, which is in fact where the word barrel for a gun comes from. She weighs around six tonnes, her bore is twenty inches across, and she could hurl a gunstone weighing about one hundred and fifty kilos over a distance of some two miles. Moving her was its own ordeal. Contemporary records suggest she could manage only about three miles a day, hauled by teams of men and oxen, so she was a strategic asset dragged laboriously to a siege, not a field gun.

James the Fourth took her to war, notably to the siege of Norham Castle in fourteen ninety-seven, but her working life was already closing. Guns evolved fast, and heavy immobile bombards were soon obsolete. Her end as a functioning weapon came in sixteen eighty-one, when she burst while firing a ceremonial salute, splitting her barrel, and you can still see the damage. She might have vanished entirely, because in seventeen fifty-four she was carted off to the Tower of London with other redundant Scottish ordnance. That she came home is thanks largely to Sir Walter Scott, the same tireless romantic who rediscovered the Honours, who campaigned for her return. In eighteen twenty-nine, by order of George the Fourth, Mons Meg was shipped back to Edinburgh in triumph, and the city gave her a hero's welcome. She's been on the rock ever since, a retired giant.